YIXING AUDIO GUIDE · PART IV

China Yixing Ceramics Museum — English Audio Guide

Complete 13-Stop Spoken Tour Script · 1.0s Sentence Pauses & 2.0s Paragraph Pauses · Total Duration: 12m 28s

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STOP 01 · 0:54 · GUZHENG & DIZI INTRO · museum_01_intro.mp3

Welcome & Introduction: China Yixing Ceramics Museum

50,000 m² Ceramic Art Landmark, 107 Graded National Cultural Relics & The China Purple Clay Museum

Hello everyone, and welcome to the China Yixing Ceramics Museum! We are standing in one of the first museums in China dedicated entirely to ceramic art. The grounds cover over 50,000 square meters, and the collection takes you through thousands of years of history.

As we walk through today, you will see everything from prehistoric pottery and Han Dynasty glazed wares to Jin Dynasty celadon, Song and Yuan Dynasty Jun pottery, and the world-famous Ming and Qing Purple Clay teapots. All together, the museum holds 107 graded national cultural relics. Over the years, this space has become a major cultural landmark, earning titles like the China Purple Clay Museum and a National 4A Tourist Attraction. Let’s step inside and see where the story begins.

STOP 02 · 1:06 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · museum_02_hall1_ancient.mp3

Hall 1: Ancient Ceramics Hall — 7,000 Years of Pottery

From Prehistoric Taihu Civilization & Jin Celadon to Song–Qing Pottery Capital (Dingshu)

Welcome to the Ancient Ceramics Hall. Yixing is known as China’s Pottery Capital, and it is one of the cradles of prehistoric civilization around Lake Taihu. Archaeologists have found that people here started making pottery more than 7,000 years ago.

As the centuries passed, local kilns kept evolving. By the Han Dynasty, Yixing was a major pottery center in southern China. During the Three Kingdoms and Jin periods, it became famous for celadon porcelain. Then, in the Song Dynasty, local potters made a major shift: they stopped making porcelain and focused entirely on pottery. By the Ming and Qing dynasties, the local town of Dingshu was famous around the world for its glazed pottery and Purple Clay wares.

Even today, you can still hear the sound of clay being beaten in workshops across almost every neighborhood in Yixing. This unbroken tradition makes Yixing one of China’s nine great kiln systems—and the only one dedicated to pottery rather than porcelain.

STOP 03 · 1:29 · BREEZE & CHIME · museum_03_celadon_jar.mp3

Hall 1 Highlight: The Celadon Granary Jar (Western Jin Dynasty)

1,700-Year-Old National First-Class Cultural Relic with 24 Solar-Term Birds, 5 Granary Tubes & 6 Dragons

Let's pause here at our first highlight: the Celadon Granary Jar. China was the first country in the world to make true porcelain, and this piece is a remarkable early example. Unearthed in Yixing in 1958, it dates back over 1,700 years to the Western Jin Dynasty. Among the nine National First-Class Cultural Relics in our museum, this is the only piece made of porcelain.

In ancient times, this jar had two uses: it was used in ceremonies to pray for a good harvest, and it was buried in tombs as a "soul jar" to accompany the dead.

If you look closely, every single detail tells a story. Around the upper rim, 24 tiny birds represent the 24 solar terms of the traditional Chinese calendar. On the body, five vertical tubes stand for a rich harvest and a thriving family. Six dragons weave in and out of the clay, symbolizing good luck and the cycle of life. Around the little pavilion, seven figures press their hands together and look up toward the sky in prayer. A raised band wraps around the middle, dividing the jar into heaven, earth, and the underworld.

Notice the texture of the glaze, too. Yixing celadon has a slightly porous clay body, so the greenish-yellow glaze sinks right into the clay, giving the jar a cool, solid, almost metallic feel.

STOP 04 · 1:01 · WATER DROPS & GUZHENG · museum_04_red_clay_jar.mp3

Hall 1 Highlight: The Double-Rimmed Red Clay Jar (Han Dynasty)

2,000-Year-Old "Ancient Natural Refrigerator" with Water-Sealed Airtight Groove

Now, let's move over to this large reddish vessel: the Double-Rimmed Red Clay Jar. This piece is over 2,000 years old, dating back to the Han Dynasty. It was unearthed locally in 1982 and later donated to the museum.

Made from local red clay, this jar shows just how clever ancient potters were with everyday household items. Look at the top of the jar, and you will see a double rim—an outer lip and an inner lip with a deep groove between them. When people stored food inside, they poured clean water into that groove and placed a lid over it. The water blocked out the air and created an airtight seal, just like a modern pickle jar. You could call it an ancient natural refrigerator!

The stamped patterns on the outside made the clay walls stronger, and the two loops on the shoulders let people thread a rope through to carry it easily. Even after 2,000 years, this jar is still completely intact.

STOP 05 · 0:45 · BAMBOO FLUTE MELODY · museum_05_hall2_jun_pottery.mp3

Hall 2: Jun-Glazed Pottery Hall ("Yijun" & Thumb-Pressing Relief)

Song Dynasty Glazed Pottery Tradition & 2014 National Intangible Cultural Heritage

Next, we are entering the Jun-Glazed Pottery Hall. Yixing Jun pottery—or "Yijun" for short—has been made in the Dingshu area since the Song Dynasty. Potters build these pieces by hand from clay slabs, brush on the glaze while the clay is still raw, and fire them once at high heat.

All the materials come right from the local hills. What makes Yijun so special is its rich, warm glaze and a unique decorating method called "thumb-pressing." Artisans use their bare thumbs to press and shape clay

directly onto the pot, creating vivid 3D relief designs. In 2014, this traditional craft was named a National Intangible Cultural Heritage.

STOP 06 · 0:43 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · museum_06_dragon_lotus_vat.mp3

Hall 2 Highlight: The Dragon-Head Lotus Vat (Ming Dynasty)

Four-Season Floral Panels, Dragon-Head Rainwater Drain Spout & Courtyard Fire-Fighting Vat

Right in front of us is a great example from the Ming Dynasty: the Dragon-Head Lotus Vat. This massive jar was built by paddling slabs of clay together. Just below the wide rim, you can spot a sculpted dragon head—that is actually a spout to let rainwater drain out so the vat wouldn't overflow.

Walk around the vat, and you will see four panels decorated with flowers for each season: peonies for spring, lotus for summer, chrysanthemums for autumn, and wintersweet for winter. Covered inside and out with a thick, glossy dark-red glaze, a vat like this sat in ancient courtyards both as a garden ornament and as a water tank to fight fires.

STOP 07 · 0:51 · BREEZE & CHIME · museum_07_ou_and_ge_kilns.mp3

Hall 2 Highlight: The Ou Kiln (Ming) & Ge Kiln (Qing)

Master Ou Ziming's Legendary Glaze & The Ge Brothers' Starry Bluish-Gray Export Wares

As we look at the glazed pieces in this case, two names stand out in the history of Yijun pottery: the Ou Kiln and the Ge Kiln.

During the Ming Dynasty, a master potter named Ou Ziming created the "Ou Kiln" style. His glazes were so refined that his works became legendary, and very few survive today outside of museums.

Later, in the Qing Dynasty, two brothers named Ge Mingxiang and Ge Yuanxiang took this craft to its peak with the "Ge Kiln." Their pottery was shipped all across Japan, Southeast Asia, and beyond. Take a look at our Ge Kiln bluish-gray vase right here. The glaze is thick and smooth, filled with tiny blue specks that look like stars scattered across the night sky.

STOP 08 · 0:51 · CLASSICAL GUZHENG · museum_08_hall3_purple_clay.mp3

Hall 3: Purple Clay Hall — The Heart of Yixing's Ceramic Fame

Ming Steeped-Tea Revolution, Huanglong Mountain Purple Clay & 16th-Century Exports to Europe

Now we have arrived at the heart of Yixing's ceramic fame: the Purple Clay Hall. Back in the 14th century, Chinese people changed the way they drank tea—instead of whisking powdered tea, they started steeping whole tea leaves. That new habit called for a new kind of teapot.

By the mid-Ming Dynasty, Yixing potters discovered that the iron-rich purple clay from nearby Huanglong Mountain was perfect for tea. Instead of throwing clay on a wheel, they beat clay strips into slabs and joined them by hand. Scholars and emperors alike fell in love with Purple Clay teapots because the clay lets the tea breathe and keeps its flavor pure. By the late 16th century, merchants were shipping these teapots all the way to Europe, where they inspired the very first European teapots.

STOP 09 · 0:53 · WATER DROPS & GUZHENG · museum_09_lotus_wine_set.mp3

Hall 3 Highlight: The Lotus Wine Set by Master Jiang Rong

Lidless Bottom-Filled Wine Pot with Internal Conical Tube by the Only Female Among the Seven Old Masters

Let's look at this bright, lifelike set first: the Lotus Wine Set, created by Master Jiang Rong. Among the famous Seven Old Masters of modern Purple Clay, Jiang Rong was the only woman. She started learning the craft at age 11 and became famous for shaping clay into plants, flowers, and animals.

At first glance, this looks like a lotus root with lotus leaves forming the handle and spout. But look closely at the top—there is no lid! So how do you pour wine into it? You actually turn the pot upside down and fill it through a hole in the bottom. Inside the pot is a cone-shaped tube that reaches higher than the spout. Once you flip the pot right-side up, the wine stays safely inside without spilling a drop. It is a brilliant mix of lifelike sculpture and clever engineering.

STOP 10 · 0:51 · BREEZE & CHIME · museum_10_wind_swept_mallow.mp3

Hall 3 Highlight: The Wind-Swept Mallow Teapot by Yang Fengnian

Qing Dynasty National First-Class Cultural Relic Capturing Invisible Wind in Solid Clay

Over here is the centerpiece of our Purple Clay Hall and a National First-Class Cultural Relic: the Wind-Swept Mallow Teapot. It was made during the Qing Dynasty by Yang Fengnian, one of the most celebrated female Purple Clay artists in history, and it is the only surviving piece of its kind.

How do you capture the invisible wind in solid clay? Yang Fengnian did it by shaping the pot like a mallow flower caught in a gust of wind. The body and lid are covered with sweeping, curved ribs that look like leaves blowing to one side. The spout is a rolled-up leaf, the lid knob is a flower bud, and the handle is a twisted stem with the artist's family seal stamped underneath. Even though the clay is completely still, the whole teapot feels full of movement and life.

STOP 11 · 0:25 · BAMBOO FLUTE MELODY · museum_11_hall4_gu_jingzhou.mp3

Hall 4: Gu Jingzhou Art Gallery

Centennial Tribute to the Greatest Purple Clay Grandmaster of the Modern Era

For the final part of our tour, let's step into the Gu Jingzhou Art Gallery. Opened in 2015 for the 100th anniversary of his birth, this quiet, classic space honors Gu Jingzhou—the greatest Purple Clay master of the modern era. Through his photos, tools, and masterpieces, you can see how he dedicated his entire life to perfecting purple clay art.

STOP 12 · 1:09 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · museum_12_tibi_tea_set.mp3

Hall 4 Highlight: The Tibi Tea Set (Gu Jingzhou & Prof. Gao Zhuang)

20-Year Collaboration (1978), Ancient Jade "Bi" Lid, Custom Tools & 1994 National Postage Stamp Masterpiece

Right here is Master Gu's crowning achievement and another National First-Class Cultural Relic: the Tibi Tea Set. Gu Jingzhou worked with Professor Gao Zhuang from the Central Academy of Arts and Design for more than 20 years to perfect this design, finally finishing it in 1978.

Unlike the flower-shaped pots we saw earlier, this set has no added decoration at all. Its beauty comes entirely from its clean lines and proportions. The flat, round lid is modeled after an ancient ceremonial jade

disc, called a “bi.” Above it, the high arched handle rises like a rainbow, blending square and round edges seamlessly.

To get every curve and edge this sharp, Gu Jingzhou had to invent more than a dozen special tools of his own. It is not just beautiful to look at—it feels balanced in the hand and pours smoothly. In fact, when China issued special postage stamps for Yixing Purple Clay in 1994, this was the only modern artwork chosen for the set.

STOP 13 · 0:59 · WATER & GUZHENG FINALE · museum_13_monks_hat_closing.mp3

Hall 4 Highlight & Finale: The Monk’s Hat Teapot (Sengmao Hu)

Six-Sided Geometric Precision, Stepped Lotus Petals, Duck-Bill Spout & Tour Closing

Let’s finish our tour at one more classic by Gu Jingzhou: the Monk’s Hat Teapot. This shape evolved from Yuan Dynasty porcelain and gets its name because the top looks just like a traditional Buddhist monk’s cap.

Building a six-sided pot like this by hand is incredibly difficult because every flat wall and sharp corner has to line up perfectly. Notice the duck-bill spout and the stepped lotus petals rising around the rim. The round knob on top looks like the crown of a hat, and right inside the petals is a tiny loop where you can tie a string to keep the lid from falling off when you pour. On the handle, a small thumb rest makes it comfortable to hold. Every part flows into the next effortlessly.

Thank you for joining me on this tour of the China Yixing Ceramics Museum. Take your time exploring the rest of the galleries, and enjoy your visit to China’s Pottery Capital!